The Lorax

By Theo Geisel (aka Dr. Seuss)

NARRATOR: At the far end of town where the Grickle-grass grows
and the wind smells slow-and-sour when it blows
and no birds ever sing excepting old crows. . .
is the Street of the Lifted Lorax.
And deep in the Grickle-grass, some people say,
if you look deep enough you can still see, today,
where the Lorax once stood just as long as it could
before somebody lifted the Lorax away.

INTRODUCTION

When Dr. Seuss gets serious, you know it must be important. Published in 1971, and perhaps inspired by the "save our planet" mindset of the 1960s, The Lorax is an ecological warning that still rings true today amidst the dangers of clear-cutting, pollution, and disregard for the earth's environment. In The Lorax, we find what we've come to expect from the illustrious doctor: brilliantly whimsical rhymes and delightfully original. But there is also something more--a powerful message that Seuss implores both adults and children to heed.

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NARRATOR: What was the Lorax? And why was it there?
And why was it lifted and taken somewhere
from the far end of town where the Grickle-grass grows?
The old Once-ler still lives here. Ask him. He knows.

ONCE-LER: Now I'll tell you, how the Lorax got lifted and taken away. . .
It all started way back. . . such a long, long time back. . .
Way back in the days when the grass was still green
and the pond was still wet and the clouds were still clean,
and the song of the Swomee-Swans rang out in space. .
one morning, I came to this glorious place.
And I first saw the trees! The Truffula Trees!
The bright-colored tufts of the Truffula Trees!
Mile after mile in the fresh morning breeze.
And under the trees, I saw Brown Bar-ba-loots
frisking about in their Bar-ba-loot suits
as they played in the shade and ate Truffula Fruits.
From the rippulous pond came the comfortable sound
of the Humming-Fish humming while splashing around.
But those trees! Those trees! Those Truffula Trees!

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All my life I'd been searching for trees such as these.
The touch of their tufts was much softer than silk.
And they had the sweet smell of fresh butterfly milk.
I felt a great leaping of joy in my heart.
I knew just what I'd do! I unloaded my cart.
In no time at all, I had built a small shop.
Then I chopped down a Truffula Tree with one chop.
And with great skillful skill and with great speedy speed,
I took the soft tuft. And I knitted a Thneed!
The instant I'd finished, I heard a ga-Zump!
I looked. I saw something pop out of the stump
of the tree I'd chopped down. It was sort of a man.
Describe him?. . . That's hard. I don't know if I can.
He was shortish. And oldish.
And brownish. And mossy.
And he spoke with a voice that was sharpish and bossy.

LORAX: *(with a sneeze)* Mister! I am the Lorax. I speak for the trees.
I speak for the trees, for the trees have no tongues.
And I'm asking you, sir, at the top of my lungs"-
What's that THING you've made out of my Truffula tuft?

ONCE-LER: Look Lorax, There's no cause for alarm.

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I chopped just one tree. I am doing no harm.
I'm being quite useful. This thing is a Thneed.
A Theend's a Fine-Something-That-All-People-Need!
It's a shirt. It's a sock. It's a glove. It's a hat.
But it has other uses. Yes, far beyond that.
You can use it for carpets. For pillows! For sheets!
Or curtains! Or covers for bicycle seats!"

LORAX: Sir! You are crazy with greed.
There is no one on Earth who would buy that fool Thneed.

ONCE-LER: But the very next minute I proved he was wrong.
For, just at that minute, a chap came along,
and he thought that the Thneed I had knitted was great.
He happily bought it for three ninety-eight.
(laughing at the Lorax) You poor stupid guy!
You never can tell what some people will buy.

LORAX: I repeat, I speak for the trees!

ONCE-LER: I'm busy. Shut up, if you please.
I rushed 'cross the room, and in no time at all,
built a radio-phone. I put in a quick call.
I called all my brothers and uncles and aunts and I said

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Listen here! Here's a wonderful chance
for the whole Once-ler Family to get mighty rich!
[They] were all knitting Theends just as busy as bees,
to the sound of the chopping of Truffula Trees.
Then . . . Oh! Baby! Oh! How the business did grow!
Now, chopping one tree at a time was too slow
So I quickly invented my Super-Axe-Hacker
which whacked off four Truffula Trees at one smacker.
We were making Thneeds four times as fast as before!
And that Lorax? . . . He knocked on my new office door.

LORAX: I'm the Lorax who speaks for the trees
which you seem to be chopping as fast as you please.
But I'm also in charge of the Brown Bar-ba-loots
who played in the shade in their Bar-ba-loot suits
and happily lived, eating Truffula Fruits.
NOW. . . thanks to your hacking my trees to the ground,
there's not enough Truffula Fruit to go 'round.
And my poor Bar-ba-loots are all getting the crummies
because they have gas, and no food, in their tummies!
They loved living here. But I can't let them stay.
They'll have to find food. And I hope that they may.

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ONCE-LER: I, the Once-ler, felt sad as I watched them all go.
BUT . . . business is business! And business must grow
I meant no harm. I most truly did not.
But I had to grow bigger. So bigger I got.
Then again he came back! I was fixing some pipes
when that old-nuisance Lorax came back with more gripes.

LORAX: *(coughing)* I am the Lorax *(sneezing, snuffling)*
Once-ler! You're making such smogulous smoke!
My poor Swomee-Swans. . . why, they can't sing a note!
No one can sing who has smog in his throat.
And so - please pardon my cough –
they cannot live here. So I'm sending them off.
What's more, let me say a few words about Gluppity-Glupp.
Your machinery chugs on, day and night without stop
making Gluppity-Glupp. Also Schloppity-Schlopp.
And what do you do with this leftover goo?. . .
I'll show you. You dirty old Once-ler man, you!
You're glumping the pond where the Humming-Fish hummed!

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No more can they hum, for their gills are all gummed.
So I'm sending them off. Oh, their future is dreary.
They'll walk on their fins and get woefully weary
in search of some water that isn't so smeary.

ONCE-LER: And then I got mad. I got terribly mad.
(yelling) Now listen here, Dad!
All you do is yap-yap and day, 'Bad! Bad! Bad! Bad!'
Well, I have my rights, sir, and I'm telling you
I intend to go on doing just what I do!
And at that very moment, we heard a loud whack!
From outside in the fields came a sickening smack
of an axe on a tree. Then we heard the tree fall.
The very last Truffula Tree of them all!
No more trees. No more Thneeds. No more work to be done.
So, in no time, my uncles and aunts, everyone,
all waved me good-bye. They jumped into my cars
and drove away under the smoke-smuggered stars.
Now all that was left 'neath the bad-smelling sky
was my big empty factory. . . the Lorax. . . and I.
The Lorax said nothing. Just gave a glance. . .
just gave a very sad, sad backward glance. . .

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as he lifted himself by the seat of his pants.
And I'll never forget the grim look on his face
when he heisted himself and took leave of this place,
through a hole in the smog, without leaving a trace.
And all that the Lorax left here in this mess
was a small pile of rocks, with the one word. . .
UNLESS. *(long pause)*
Whatever that meant, well, I just couldn't guess.
That was long, long ago.
But each day since that day I've sat here and worried
and worried away.
Through the years, while my buildings have fallen apart,
I've worried about it with all of my heart.
But now. . . Now that you're here, the word of the Lorax
seems perfectly clear.
UNLESS someone like you cares a whole awful lot,
nothing is going to get better . . . It's not.
SO. . . Catch! *(he tosses something down)*
It's a Truffula Seed. It's the last one of all!
You're in charge of the last of the Truffula Seeds.
And Truffula Trees are what everyone needs.
Plant a new Truffula. Treat it with care.

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Give it clean water. And feed it fresh air.

Grow a forest. Protect it from axes that hack.

Then the Lorax and all of his friends may come back.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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